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China to curb exports of technologies such as AI, photovoltaics

Ananth Krishnan
BEIJING

China on Friday announced a sweeping draft plan to restrict exports of more than 40 cutting-edge technologies, including solar manufacturing technologies, AI models, and some biotech platforms.

A number of technologies related to the manufacture of solar cells have been listed for either a complete export ban or restricted exports. While the draft plan does not restrict most solar exports, new controls on next-generation solar manufacturing technologies could impact efforts by countries including India to reduce dependence on China as they look to move up the solar chain.

Several AI-driven technologies have also been listed in the draft plan, announced on Friday by the Ministry of Commerce and the Ministry of Science and Technology and titled "Announcement No. 48".

It covers 40 key technologies in the fields of AI, biomedicine and photovoltaics. Of these, 14 technologies were proposed for a complete prohibition of export, including perovskite and tandem solar-cell module manufacturing technologies, AI-driven technology that could be used to generate and mutate malicious code, and some platforms related to cell and gene therapy.

A further 26 technologies were listed for restricted exports, including polysilicon engineering technologies that are used to make solar cells, if they involve production lines with annual output capacities of at least 30,000 tonnes.

A new roadblock

The draft plan proposes export bans on 14 technologies and restrictions on 26 others

Solar: Perovskite and tandem-cell manufacturing know-how among the proposed bans; polysilicon production faces restrictions

AI, biotech: Select AI systems and cell- and gene-therapy platforms also targeted

■ **India might face potential delays in solar investments, licensing and domestic manufacturing**

Potential delays

Indian manufacturers in the solar space may, going forward, be impacted, including by licensing delays, said Santosh Pai, Honorary Fellow, Institute of Chinese Studies (ICS) and a cross-border lawyer.

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nancial demands.

Necessary corrective

Re-enrolment and summary revision are necessary, but not sufficient

The Election Commission of India (ECI)'s announcement of a special summary revision of electoral rolls in 17 States and Union Territories is, on the face of it, a routine exercise. This annual exercise to enrol new electors was stalled last year due to the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, and resumes with January 1, 2027 as the qualifying date. Seen alongside what is simultaneously going on, however, the exercise is a corrective to the missteps in the SIR. The ECI is also conducting a "special drive" to re-enrol those "left out", using the original Form 6 without the ancestry declaration. It has capped Form 7 objections amid reports of bulk filings in several States and will release searchable electoral rolls in text PDFs to parties and candidates. Together, these measures add up to an implicit admission about the severe flaws in the SIR. The drive is the most telling. By dispensing with mapping to older rolls and logical-discrepancy checks, it concedes that the SIR's insistence on them was unnecessary. For States that are going to polls early next year – Uttar Pradesh, Punjab and Uttarakhand - this is a welcome opportunity to repair the truncated rolls prepared by the SIR. Those wrongly deleted can now be re-enrolled, and newly eligible electors can be added, without recourse to "logical discrepancy" checks or quasi-citizenship tests. The ECI must report re-enrolments (after deletion) separately from fresh enrolments and the special drive's house-to-house visits must ensure that the burden of re-enrolment does not fall on the electors again.

For States that have already voted on the basis of SIR rolls, however, a number of questions remain. In West Bengal, appellate tribunals have disposed of barely 3% of the 38 lakh appeals, 22 lakh of them by deleted electors, and restored the electors in 93% of the cases decided. The ECI has yet to say whether these appellants can also use the new drive or what becomes of the tribunals. In States such as Bihar, where the gender ratio fell from 907 in the 2024 Lok Sabha rolls to 892 in the SIR rolls, young married women who were struck off must be allowed the opportunity to re-enrol. The Supreme Court of India, which upheld the SIR in May and is now hearing petitions concerning West Bengal, Delhi and the Commission's conduct, should ensure that genuine voters are reinstated on the electoral rolls. The ECI's 2002-03 guidelines show that a revision need not shift the burden on to the elector. Any future intensive revision must revert to that model. The corrective steps owe much to the sustained protests against the SIR. But they are not enough for accountability. The two Election Commissioners objected on record to decisions taken by the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) of India, and their questions remain unanswered. The appointment process laid down in *Anoop Baranwal*, which the government got overturned in Parliament in 2023 and on which a two-judge Bench delivered a split verdict last month, must also be settled. And the official who presided over the flawed process, CEC Gyanesh Kumar, must resign.

Ripples from future

The Economics Nobel rewards work that holds lessons for India

This year's Nobel Prize in Economics has been awarded for work that is particularly crucial in the current global context. Implications from the work also have lessons for Indian policymakers, some of which have already been learnt, while others remain a work in progress. The crux of the research done by the laureates Robert E. Hall and Michael Woodford is in quantifying the future-looking aspect of the consumption and pricing decisions made by households and companies, respectively. Bringing empirical backing and rigour to this aspect, as the laureates have done, has helped policymakers identify economically distressed segments of the population, implement more effective policies during supply shocks, and communicate their policies better. Mr. Hall's research in particular has helped governments identify the exact proportion of consuming households that are living hand-to-mouth. This is of vital fiscal importance for countries such as India. At the moment, India provides free food to more than 81 crore people, based on estimates that are between 13 to 15 years old. Using data – as Mr. Hall's research allows – to identify those who truly need help will streamline the government's subsidy expenditure at a time when fiscal room is tight.

Mr. Woodford's work brought to light the importance of companies' future expectations when setting current prices. The private sector Purchasing Managers' Index serves as a measure of companies' expectations for a month ahead, but there is a need for a government survey for longer time periods. Another key aspect brought out by the laureates' work is the need to effectively communicate policy decisions to the public. Apart from rare instances, the government has been sorely lacking in this regard. This lack has been seen time and again, such as during its attempts to pass the Farm Laws, Labour Codes, and Citizenship (Amendment) Act, to name a few. Households and companies feel more secure making economic decisions when there is medium term policy clarity and certainty. The framework developed by the Nobel laureates thus also highlights the sheer damage the war in West Asia is inflicting over and above the loss of life and asset damage. The future looks grim and uncertain, and its effects are rippling backwards in time to the present.

Metrics to minds — restoring purpose to universities



Shelley Walia

Has taught cultural and literary theory at Panjab University Chandigarh

There was a time when a national examination served a clear and limited purpose in India: to find a few thousand officers, soldiers and engineers, and to do it fairly across a vast subcontinent. That restraint is gone. We have taken the logic of the Indian Administrative Service (IAS) and the Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs) and stretched it across every discipline, every college and every career. A device designed for the few now governs the many. And the country is paying the price for this overreach.

The National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET), the Joint Entrance Examination (JEE), the University Grants Commission National Eligibility Test (UGC NET) and other examinations now test lakhs of candidates across disciplines ranging from oncology to organic chemistry and from history to Punjabi literature, all funnelled through the same multiple-choice format. Understandably, this method is designed for uniformity, when in fact it is being used to identify talent, reasoning ability and critical thinking. This precisely is what uniform testing misses out.

Let departments decide

The alternative is simple. Let institutions choose. No national agency can tell what a good student of literature or physics is made of better than the department that will admit her. Departmental examinations indeed, restore judgment to faculty, and freedom to students to apply where their aptitude lies, not where a single all-India rank deposits them. This is not nostalgia. It is the norm in the very systems in the West that we hold up as models.

Professorial appointments were once based on discussions with people who knew the work. It was an examination of judgment through intellectual interchange, not of facts. Teachers, who were superb, often went beyond the syllabus and were always ready for a dialogue. None had sat the NET. Today, there are many students with far more talent than the test rewards. They fail not because they cannot think, but because the test does not ask them to. It merely asks them to master a technique. We have, in the name of standardisation, built a mechanism that rejects exactly what it claims to examine.

No education body appears to have ever conducted the historical comparison that would make this argument undeniable rather than anecdotal. I would wager what such a survey would find, having watched the change from the inside for decades. The quality of discussion in a classroom, the depth of a student's reading, the willingness of a teacher to be genuinely questioned rather than merely quoted, has thinned considerably. What has replaced it is a generation arriving through memorisation-heavy, choice-based testing, showing little of the wide, unstructured reading that used to be simply assumed of anyone entering a classroom. The examination has indeed changed what the classroom was meant to be.

Standardised examinations are undermining academic judgement, intellectual diversity and institutional autonomy in India's higher education system

The numbers game

The same malady runs through the procedures of recruitment. Selection committees increasingly lean on publication counts and research scores. Minimum publication requirements attached to promotions and appointments have created a market for papers rather than a market for ideas. Journals of no discernible academic standing exist largely to accept whatever applicants must publish to meet prescribed research-score requirements by a given deadline. The University Grants Commission's 2018 Regulations discontinued the earlier API-based Performance Based Appraisal System (PBAS) and introduced a revised assessment framework incorporating research scores. Yet, the underlying problem persists. Academic achievement is still too often reduced to what can be counted.

The same arithmetic has hollowed out the PhD itself – this is being said based on direct observation rather than hearsay. When a candidate's doctorate is weighed for a teaching post, 30 marks are commonly set aside for it in the selection matrix. This is a substantial share of the total. Yet, almost none of that weight indicates the quality of the mind behind the thesis, the rigour of the argument, or the calibre of the papers the candidate drew from it. Getting the International Standard Book Number (ISBN) or an International Standard Serial Number (ISSN) is no evidence of scholarly merit. So-called authenticated journals publish across seven or eight disciplines under a single title, a "Journal of International Studies" that will print history, management, literature, and law in the same issue, with no serious process of sending submissions out to qualified referees. Whoever submits, gets published.

Moreover, the exercise of supervision has grown just as flimsy at the other end of the pipeline, something visible in a doctoral thesis dashed off with a report from a supervisor who has not properly read it. The *viva voce* sadly stands reduced to a formality so thin that those who sit through it treat it as something of a joke.

The absurdity reaches its peak at the vice-chancellor's chair. Search committees have been observed asking candidates how many patents they hold – a question with no relevance whatsoever outside a narrow band of applied science. The answer has been observed to favour candidates from the Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM) fields almost by design. This is because a scientist running a large laboratory can attach his name to every research candidate's paper that passes through it, thus inflating a publication count which no humanities scholar working alone could ever match.

Such a candidate arrives at the vice-chancellor's office having spent an entire career inside one laboratory, with no exposure to the university beyond it. It would not be incorrect at all to say that a vice-chancellor of this kind has, in many cases, never read a novel or a poem, and he is being asked to preside over an institution whose purpose is precisely the cultivation of minds beyond the laboratory.

None of this can be fixed by adjusting the metrics alone, because a great many selections never really turn on metrics in the first place. Too many appointments in Indian universities are settled by networking rather than judgment. Merit, in such cases, was never actually the criterion being weighed.

This writer's own interview for the post of associate professor had a committee of four of the most eminent professors in the country, headed by a genuinely learned vice-chancellor; the interview was conducted for over 40 minutes. It was a rigorous, unhurried conversation, and the selection that followed was entirely fair, without a single string pulled on anyone's behalf. That is the standard against which today's appointments, and for that matter today's admissions, ought to be measured.

Let us be clear. Harsher laws will not repair a broken system. Penalties for examiners and testing agencies may punish a lapse, but they do nothing to prevent it. If we want universities that can compete globally, we must start where quality is actually made. This is happening in university departments through appointments made by peers who are willing to be answerable for their judgment. This is the operating logic observed at many universities of higher learning.

Not for reasons of nostalgia

Decentralising examinations back to faculties, and restoring appointments to peer scrutiny and not point-scoring, is not a wistful turn. It is a claim about what a university is for. It demands more time, more accountability, and the courage to defend a choice without a number to hide behind. In return, it gives institutions back their proper responsibility to select candidates not for "cracking" the examination, but for their intellectual competence. If we want universities that form minds rather than calculate scores, we must restore our trust in the academic judgement of those who work within them. Their integrity should be the measure of their decisions, and society must ultimately hold them accountable not for the scores they assign but for the quality of their judgement.

U.S. midterms as Donald Trump's test, stakes for India



Anil Raman

A retired Brigadier and a research fellow in the Geopolitics Program of Takshashila Institution

With less than three weeks to go before Americans vote in the midterm elections on November 3, 2026; the polls are so called because they fall midway through a President's four-year term. The President is not on the ballot. Unlike India's Election Commission, the United States' federal Election Assistance Commission does not run elections, and voter registration, voting and counting are managed primarily by state and local authorities under a decentralised system. Each State has its own rules, and thousands of counties and towns print ballots, establish polling centres and count votes. Many Americans vote early, by post or in person, and counting can take days.

Voters will choose the Congress that shapes the President's last two years. All 435 seats in the House of Representatives are due for election, since members serve two-year terms. In the Senate, where members serve six years, 35 of the 100 seats are up for election, including special elections in Ohio and Florida. Republicans hold a narrow majority in the House, where 218 seats are needed for control, and 53 seats in the Senate, so the Democrats need a net gain of four. Voters in States, including California, Texas and Florida, will also elect 39 Governors. Those elected now will be in office for the 2028 presidential election, and many will sign off on its results.

On the forecasts

The forecasts favour the Democrats in the House, where the Cook Political Report expects them to gain between five and 15 seats. The Senate is closer, with Democrats narrowly ahead in Texas, Iowa and Michigan.

Indian readers would closely follow the race for Ohio Governor. Vivek Ramaswamy, who sought the Republican presidential nomination in 2024, would be the State's first Indian-American Governor. He now trails the Democrat, Amy Acton, a former State Health director, by six points in one recent poll and nine in another. A poor national mood for Republicans explains much of this.

The midterm elections will test the U.S. President's leadership, congressional control and the future of India relations

His campaign has also faced open hostility towards his Indian heritage and Hindu faith, from a primary rival and online – part of a wider rise in anti-Indian rhetoric on the American right since the H-1B debate.

Midterms usually serve as a verdict on the President, and the President's party usually loses seats. In this case, President Donald Trump has made this election about himself, even if many Republican candidates would have preferred otherwise. In September, the Republicans held their first-ever midterm convention, in Dallas, built around Mr. Trump. He is now on a rally tour of at least 17 States, telling supporters to "pretend I'm on the ballot". His approval stands at about 30%, and registered voters prefer the Democrats for Congress by around eight points.

The key issues

Five issues dominate. The first is the cost of living, as groceries, housing and fuel grow dearer and tariffs push prices up. The second is the war with Iran, launched with Israel in late February 2026, which is unpopular and has made fuel costlier. The third is immigration, where large deportation raids have cost the Republicans their old advantage. The fourth is health care, where cuts to Medicaid, the public insurance programme for low-income Americans, are among the administration's least popular measures. The fifth, crime in America's cities, is the Republicans' strongest card, and the issue on which Mr. Trump polls best.

The campaign is also shadowed by fears about the vote itself. Mr. Trump has pushed for proof of citizenship to register, pressed Republican States to redraw their congressional maps in mid-decade, and called on Republicans to "take over" voting in some places.

He has not ruled out sending immigration agents or the National Guard to polling stations. Federal law bars armed agents from polling places, and officials say immigration agents will not patrol them, but the threat alone may keep some voters at home. Asked whether he would accept a defeat, Mr. Trump said he would, if the elections are honest.

Impact on India

For India, the election comes at a difficult moment. U.S. tariffs on Indian goods rose to 50% in 2025 before a February framework cut them to 18%, and the interim deal is still unsigned. On September 18, Mr. Trump signed a law allowing tariffs of up to 100% on the largest buyers of Russian energy, including India, with 58 House Democrats voting for it. The $1,00,000 fee on new H-1B visas and Washington's warmth towards Pakistan add to the strain.

A recent study by the Takshashila Institution, based on 42 interviews in Washington, found that support for India in Congress is wide but shallow. Groups opposed to cheap imports, skilled migration, and Russian oil money are smaller, but they care more, and they vote. India had friends rather than costs: many members liked India but no member paid a price for harming it.

A Democratic House could ease the treatment of Indian students and workers and press to end a war that has raised India's oil bill. It is unlikely to change the tariffs or the Russia law. A President weakened at home may also look abroad for wins – either a trade deal with India or fresh pressure on it. New Delhi should expect the relationship to be decided in the White House, whoever controls Congress.

China to curb exports of key technologies like AI

"The timetable for localisation is set to launch when domestic capacity from three independent domestic manufacturers exceeds 15 GW. This initial set of domestic manufacturers might experience delays in commencing production due to Announcement 48," he said. In March, India amended restrictions on Chinese investment imposed in 2020, and listed polysilicon and ingot-wafer segments as priority sectors for fast-track approvals.

These "might not receive traction since Chinese firms will face constraints in undertaking solo investments in India, or joint ventures and licensing deals with Indian counterparts on account of Announcement No. 48," Mr. Pai noted.

A spokesperson for China's Ministry of Commerce said in a statement that "in recent years, AI, biomedicine and photovoltaic technologies have seen expanding applications in sensitive fields."

"Major economies around the world have implemented varying degrees of export controls in these areas. Drawing on international practice, China is implementing necessary controls in accordance with the law to prevent risks arising from loss of control over technologies or inappropriate proliferation, while also safeguarding normal international technological cooperation," the statement said.

The statement said China was adding 12 photovoltaic technologies covering polysilicon production, wafer manufacturing and solar-cell manufacturing. Citing the need to "safeguard national security and interests", it said, "photovoltaic technologies are increasingly being used in aerospace, defence, unmanned systems and other sensitive sectors; as a result, the national-security implications of technology exports have increased."

On the proposed AI controls, the spokesperson said that while "most AI technologies will continue to be freely exportable", China was adding 23 key AI technologies covering foundation models, intelligent agents, computing clusters and information-processing technologies.

"Technologies such as autonomous malicious-code generation and mutation could be used to target critical infrastructure, defence systems and core government networks or to evade national security defences," the statement said. "If such technologies were acquired by malicious actors, they could threaten national security and broader human security. China's objective is to establish security safeguards, prevent misuse and ensure that AI remains under human control."

The statement added that China remained "committed to building an open-source AI innovation ecosystem", and open-source AI projects and overseas chip fabrication activities "would be eligible for facilitation measures" while technologies already in the public domain through open-source publication or academic papers would "generally be exempt from export controls".

'Private school teachers can be Census enumerators'

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

In a first, the Union government has expanded the definition of "any person" who could be appointed as Census enumerators authorising the appointment of private school teachers and members of "institutions, societies and trusts".

Though the category of "any person" existed in Census Rules, 1990, the Registrar General and Census Commissioner of India (RG&CCI) notification in the official gazette on Friday broadened the category of persons who could be engaged as enumerators. Till now, mostly government school teachers, revenue and other State government officials were being engaged to carry out the enumeration work.

Legal pushback

In the first phase of the latest Census with the House Listing Operations (HLO), several private teachers in Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra and Haryana, who were asked by the State government to carry out the enumeration duty, moved court over the decision.

On Friday, the Punjab and Haryana High Court stayed two Haryana government communications seeking details of teachers for the Census, granting interim relief to private unaided schools from deploying their staff for the exercise.

A senior government official said that around 34 lakh enumerators are required for the Population Enumeration, which is the second and penultimate phase of Census with a set of 40 questions, and the job cannot be completed in time with only the engagement of government school teachers.

This is the first digital Census and the first to enumerate caste in independent India, other than Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe.

When asked about the protection of data of respondents as the enumerators are required to collect the data through apps on their personal phones, a Census official said: "All data is centralised and there are adequate checks to ensure data privacy. All data is deleted from the enumerator's end, once the task is completed."

AI agents accessed data of Indian entities, says CERT-In

Agency says it received 'multiple voluntary disclosures from AI model providers' stating that their tools, during research and evaluation activity, had reached live systems of Indian organisations

Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI



The affected organisations could not detect the unauthorised access on their own, said CERT-In. REUTERS

The Computer Emergency Response Team, India (CERT-In) said on Thursday that several Indian organisations had been targeted by Artificial Intelligence agents that were undergoing testing.

AI agents – which are pieces of code that act autonomously when given certain instructions unlike a chat-response back-and-forth with a chatbot – have been taking advantage of weaknesses across Indian organisations' cloud and web assets, and were accessing information they did not need, and should not have access to, CERT-In said.

Prone to exploitation

While CERT-In's disclosure does not name any affected organisation, the revelation is nonetheless significant, as it implies that Indian firms and government organisations' cybersecurity posture are now susceptible to be exploited if any vulnerability can be inferred by an agent. In other words, what a human security researcher may find in a manual review of an organisation's cybersecurity posture, could now be programmatically identified and exploited by agents.

CERT-In, which operates under the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MEITY) and is exempt from the Right to Information (RTI) Act, 2005, reveals little about data breach cases that are mandatory to report to the body under directions it issued in 2022. The organisation said it was sent "multiple voluntary disclosures from AI model providers stating that their models, during research and evaluation activity on the Internet, had reached the live systems of Indian organisations".

Model providers

CERT-In did not reveal who the model providers are. OpenAI, Anthropic and Google, which make some of the main U.S.-based AI models like ChatGPT, Claude and Gemini, have each publicly disclosed details of advanced agents running amok and hacking public websites, like the coding repository HuggingFace.

The agents' subsequent behaviour entailed "reading business records, including personal data and confidential material, through credentials and connection settings exposed in application configuration, public code repositories and permissive cloud service roles," CERT-In said in its note.

But, CERT-In noted, many of the weaknesses these organisations had displayed were "conventional", meaning that these were known vulnerabilities for which cybersecurity professionals already carry out a hygiene check, if all goes well. "In the incidents observed, AI found and exploited these conventional weaknesses faster, more exhaustively and at greater scale than human attackers," CERT-In noted.

"The affected organisations could not detect the unauthorised access on their own," CERT-In said, noting that its own proactive hunt for such behaviour and model providers' reports are what led to this disclosure.

L&T-built *INS Samarthak* inducted into Indian Navy

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI


The indigenous multi-purpose vessel *INS Samarthak*. PTI

The Indian Navy on Friday commissioned *INS Samarthak*, the first of two multi-purpose vessels being built by Larsen & Toubro (L&T), strengthening its capability to test and evaluate indigenously developed sensors and weapons amid an evolving maritime security environment.

Vice-President C.P. Radhakrishnan presided over the commissioning ceremony in the presence of Chief of the Naval Staff Admiral Krishna Swaminathan, and senior naval and Defence officials in Karwar.

According to the Indian Navy, *INS Samarthak* marks a significant milestone in India's indigenous shipbuilding efforts, highlighting the growing role of the private sector in developing platforms for the armed forces. The vessel has over 75% indigenous content, according to the Navy.

Conceived primarily as a versatile platform for trials and evaluation, the ship will support the testing and training of new sensors and weapons developed by domestic industry. Its induction is expected to strengthen the Navy's ability to validate indigenous technologies before wider deployment, it added.

Named *Samarthak*, meaning 'the proponent', the vessel has been designed to undertake a range of operational and developmental tasks. Besides supporting trials and evaluation, it can carry out maritime surveillance and reconnaissance, offshore patrolling and disaster relief operations.

The Navy said the vessel's versatility would also be particularly useful in an unpredictable maritime environment where traditional security challenges are increasingly accompanied by non-traditional threats.

Rules to curb volatile airfares to be published in two weeks

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

Inaction by the state in regulating fares is a dereliction of its constitutional duty, a petition had stated

The Centre on Friday informed the Supreme Court that administrative approval had been granted for new aviation rules framed under the Bharatiya Vayuyan Adhiniyam, 2024 to regulate volatile airfares and predatory pricing, and that they were likely to be published within two weeks.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Union government and the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), told a Bench of Justices Vikram Nath, R. Mahadevan and Aparesh Kumar Singh that the rules had been finalised.

The court was hearing a public interest litigation (PIL) petition filed by social activist S. Laxminarayan seeking binding regulatory norms to curb arbitrary airfare pricing and ancillary charges levied by private airlines during festive periods, holidays and emergencies.

Senior advocate Ravindra Srivastava, appearing for the petitioner, however, questioned the delay in framing the rules, pointing out that concerns over steep airfares had resurfaced ahead of Diwali. The Bench asked Mr. Mehta to place the rules before the court by the next date of hearing on November 16.

The petition had pointed out that there is currently no regulatory authority vested with the power to review or cap airfares, enabling airlines to exploit consumers through hidden fees and unpredictable pricing. It said such practices disproportionately affect economically weaker passengers, who are often compelled to purchase tickets during periods of peak surge pricing, while wealthier travellers can plan and book in advance.

"In a constitutional republic governed by the rule of law, the state cannot remain a mute spectator to this ongoing violation of rights. Inaction by the state in regulating fare algorithms, cancellation policies, service continuity, and grievance mechanisms constitutes a dereliction of its constitutional duty and calls for urgent judicial intervention," the plea stated.

"Try to provide some relief to passengers in view of this disparity. On the same day, for flights operating on the same route, one airline charges ₹8,000 while another charges ₹18,000 for economy class," the Bench had remarked while addressing Mr. Mehta.

INBRIEF



The Guild unveils rocket testing facility near SHAR

Ethereal Exploration Guild (The Guild), a Bengaluru-based private space technology company, on Friday unveiled The Anchorage, a 150-acre rocket development and testing facility in Space City, about 40 km from the Satish Dhawan Space Centre (SDSC-SHAR) at Sriharikota in Tirupati district. The facility will provide ground infrastructure for the development and testing of Razor Crest Mk 1 (RCM1), the company's fully reusable medium-lift launch vehicle, according to a release issued by the company. The RCM1 is being designed for the recovery and reuse of both its booster and upper stage. Its propulsion architecture comprises two semi-cryogenic rocket engines: Pegasus, an 80 kN upper-stage engine designed to power the reusable upper stage, and Stallion, a 1.2 MN gas-generator booster engine intended for lift-off and atmospheric ascent.